



And then it was time to bid a tearful goodbye and head to the St. Regis, champagne flute in hand. The glum mood didn't last, and I was soon in the swing of things. One of the most striking things about the St. Regis are its iconic rituals. These include champagne sabering—of which we witnessed a spirited demonstration at dusk—afternoon tea, Midnight Supper (you need sustenance after those crazy parties, right?) and, best of all, the Bloody Mary ritual. Cocktail aficionados will know that the Bloody Mary was created at the St. Regis New York in 1934. Every St. Regis in the world has its own version (and there's even a recipe book which holds them all). The Langkawi version is the pandan and lemongrass-inflected Lang Mary, and we all had a turn at trying to produce a decent one. Mine was a spectacular failure, but the disappointment was short lived because the ace bartender soon presented me with a 10/10 version, a perfect accompaniment to watching the sun go down as the otters played in the bay. This was followed by a four-hands gourmet dinner at Kayuputi, the resort's haute-Asian restaurant. Languorous, and thoughtfully paired with the finest burgundies, I will remember that meal for a long time to come.

It really boils down to the sort of holiday you want. If it's activity-fuelled family time you seek, then the Ritz-Carlton, Langkawi is the one for you (kids will love the paper-making workshop or the opportunity to peek into the hotel's sustainability initiatives, especially the sea cucumber reproduction project). And if your idea of the perfect holiday is to do nothing at all—pool to gourmet lunch to nap to pool, and repeat—then it doesn't get any better than the St. Regis here. Of course, it goes without saying that both have excellent spas (although the Ritz-Carlton's award-winning spa architecture, inspired by traditional Malay bubus or fish traps, will take your breath away). If you ask me, it's not possible to choose one above the other—you simply have to try both.



THE INFORMATION

THE RITZ-CARLTON, LANGKAWI

Accommodation:
90 luxurious guest rooms and suites and 29 pool villas
Tariff: From MYR 2,810 (₹66,000 per night), incl. breakfast and taxes
Address and contact:
PT 313 Jalan Pantai Kok, Teluk Nibung, Langkawi, Malaysia, 07000;
+60-4-9524888 (toll-free)

THE ST. REGIS LANGKAWI

Accommodation:
85 luxuriously-appointed rooms & suites and 4 private overwater villas
Tariff: From MYR 2,210 (₹52,000 per night), incl. breakfast and taxes
Address and contact:
Jalan Pantai Beringin, Langkawi, Malaysia, 07000;
+1-80-080-6554 (toll-free)

Website:
www.marriott.com